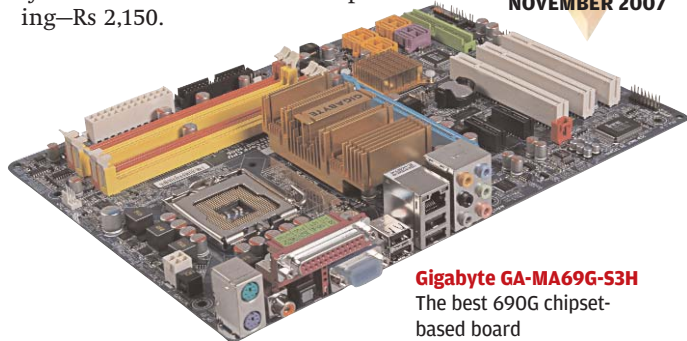


Although NVIDIA's 7050 / 7025-based boards trail behind, we won't be too critical—simply because these chipsets are really new, and we newer drivers should optimise things for better performance. The Abit AN-M2HD and the Galaxy AN68M boards were the only ones to cross the 190 fps mark.

Verdict

With everyone jumping on the Core 2 Duo bandwagon, it seems AMD is left out in the cold for now. However, we've seen a few solid platforms for AMD processors, and these do make viable solutions for those looking for a powerful multimedia or Home Entertainment PC. If you're looking for value, it's hard to ignore the Galaxy AN68M. A spanking new chipset that promises a lot, decent layout and expandability, HDMI connectivity (for home-cinema buffs)—all this at an unbelievable price of Rs 3,300! If you want something with a little more punch, we recommend the MSI K9AGM2 (690G)—priced a little higher at Rs 4,000. It's got support for 8 GB of memory on 4 DIMM's, and HDMI.

Gigabyte's GA-MA69G-S3H is our Gold winner for AMD's processors—a great combination of features and performance. The Zebtronics ZEB-N61M2 steals silver mainly because of its unbeatable pricing—Rs 2,150.



Gigabyte GA-MA69G-S3H
The best 690G chipset-based board

In Retrospect

Going by the steady increase in the number of players (and the number of products), our markets are teeming with options for various kinds of solutions. The enthusiast options—motherboards that come with *everything*—at a price.

Then there are those products aimed at prosumers—who are less discerning than enthusiasts. Home Cinema buffs will also find something from among our plethora of options.

Just when you think, "Hey—couldn't get much better, right?" something new comes out! Intel's new Penryn processors are about to enter the consumer space—and a whole new platform (Intel's X38) with support for an FSB speed of 1600 MHz among a host of other goodies!

NVIDIA has promised a successor to their 680i chipset, we don't even know whether it'll be called the 780i or something else, but we're as excited as the next guy! We've already seen the still shiny P35 become a reliable, powerful platform.

Then there's the AgenaFX / Agena from AMD—the desktop spin off from their workstation processor Barcelona. New processor equals new platform. So much for 2008!

2009 should see the advent of native six- and eight-core processors in the form of AMD's Sandtiger and Intel's Nehalem—both of which should make today's quad-cores look prehistoric. ☒

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